

Swanzeny Strategic Review — Two-Page Summary

Restraint and Its Limits · Prepared for the Board of Selectmen · PublicLogic VAULT · v0.1 · June 2026

The argument: Swanzeny leads with **restraint**. It built a decade of voter trust — and, used the same way again, it will starve the Town's capital and erode that trust. Don't abandon restraint; **upgrade the instrument**: save first, leverage outside money, tell residents the plain truth.

A. By the numbers (2012–2026)

Metric	Where it stands	What it means
Operating budget	\$5.75M → \$8.94M (+55%)	Now +6–7%/yr — health, wages, retirement, ambulance; not new programs
Budget voter support	~81% → 57%	Trust eroding even though taxes were held
Reserves & tax credits	pass 78–90%	The town will SAVE
Facility bonds (need 3/5)	55–58% — failed 2024 & 2026	The town won't BORROW; a majority isn't enough at the 3/5 wall
Default vs. proposed budget	within \$47K (2026)	'Vote no to save' no longer works; in 2017/18/23 the default was higher
Total tax rate	\$24.51 (2021) → \$20.18 (2025)	2024 drop was a revaluation, not a cut; ~60% of the bill is school/county
Town administrators	3 in ~2 years	Continuity is the scarcest resource
New obligation	West Swanzeny water (2025)	A multi-million utility now on the books

B. The pattern — confidence up, capacity down

The consistent choice	Evidence	Effect
Say yes to small, no to big	credits ~90%, reserves ~78%, bonds 55–58%	Confidence ↑ · capital ↓
Build budgets to the bone	default ≈ proposal	Lean & trusted ↑ · flexibility ↓
Defer big capital	no facility reserve; facility stuck	Taxes held now ↑ · deficit later ↓
Hold the tax line	rate restraint for years	Confidence ↑ — until the deficits show, then ↓

C. What we would do differently — and why

Today leads with...	We'd lead with...	Why	First step
"No" to debt	Save first + leverage aid	Majority vote, not 3/5; unlocks capital	Stand up the reserve ladder (Q2)
Lean annual budgets	A published 6-year CIP	Surprises become expectations; smooths the rate	CIP committee drafts it (Q1)
One-off bond asks	Majority-vote reserves	Clears the 3/5 wall the town keeps hitting	Warrant reserve articles (Q2)
Tax-rate headlines	Bill + value transparency	Defuses revaluation confusion	One-page explainer (Q1)
Reacting to turnover	An administrator continuity compact	Protects every other initiative	Multi-year TA agreement (Q1)
Case-by-case land use	Criteria-based decisions on the record	Cuts litigation exposure (Avanru)	Counsel at land-use hearings

D. Financing the backlog — the math that makes it safe

Lever	Effect
Stack outside money first	State bridge aid (80%, RSA 234), DWSRF water repaid by rates, CDBG/road aid → ~62% of a ~\$5.3M backlog is NON-property-tax money
Reserves, not bonds	Local share (~\$2.0M) saved via simple-majority reserves — \$0 new bonds, no 3/5 votes
Phase it	Net-new impact peaks ≈ +\$75/yr on a \$300K home, then drops BELOW today once built

E. Twelve-month plan

Quarter	Moves
Q1	Stabilize the administrator (multi-year agreement + evaluation) · publish a draft 6-year CIP · issue the tax-bill explainer
Q2	Pass the capital reserve ladder (majority votes) · file State Bridge Aid for Christian Hill Rd · commission the water rate study
Q3	Advance DWSRF water financing · deliver one visible 'small win' (ADA via CDBG + reserve) · adopt 5-member board norms
Q4	Bring the full CIP + reserve plan to the deliberative session with an info night · report the year's progress publicly

The ask: Endorse one principle — **keep the restraint, change the instrument** — and direct staff to (1) stabilize the administrator, (2) stand up the reserve ladder and a published CIP, and (3) pursue bridge aid and DWSRF for the big items. No new bonds. No tax spike.

Real figures from the Town of Swanze's own annual reports (2011–2025), NH DRA, and local news; capital figures and forecasts are clearly-labeled planning estimates. Companion: full Strategic Review (v0.1), financial model, and capital plan.